

Studying Development of Psychopathology Across the Lifespan

Isaac T. Petersen, Zachary Demko, and Megan Schumer

Department of Psychological and Brain Sciences, University of Iowa

Author Note

Isaac T. Petersen  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-3072-6673>

Zachary Demko  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-5717-6205>

Megan Schumer  <https://orcid.org/0009-0009-5488-6541>

The data for the present study are published online: [LINK]. We have no conflicts of interest to disclose. The present study was approved by the University of Iowa Institutional Review Board (Study #: INSERT). The authors complied with APA ethical standards in the treatment of participants. I.P. was funded by Grant HD098235 from the Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Institutes of Health. We thank Jordan L. Harris and Alexis Hosch for their help identifying measures of externalizing problems and transcribing and coding their content. Author roles were classified using the Contributor Role Taxonomy (CRediT; <https://credit.niso.org>) as follows: Isaac T. Petersen: conceptualization, data curation, analysis, funding, investigation, methodology, project administration, resources, software, supervision, validation, visualization, writing, editing; Zachary Demko: conceptualization, data curation, analysis, investigation, methodology, software, editing; Megan Schumer: editing

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Isaac T. Petersen, University of Iowa, G60 Psychological and Brain Sciences Building, Iowa City, IA 52242. Email: isaac-t-petersen@uiowa.edu

Abstract

The field has not adequately studied individuals' development of psychopathology across the lifespan, instead taking a piecewise approach to development, limiting our understanding of lifespan development and the origins of psychopathology. We describe why this is the case—beyond logistical challenges. First, diagnostic and taxonomic systems do not define psychopathology constructs from a developmental perspective. A developmental perspective is crucial because psychopathology constructs often have earlier origins than their full clinical presentation, and forms of psychopathology frequently show changes in behavioral manifestation across development (heterotypic continuity). Second, current assessments do not adequately capture these changes in behavioral manifestation. Third, traditional scoring systems do not allow charting individuals' change over time in the face of changing behavioral manifestation. Fourth, assessments are not well-suited for capturing individual differences, despite the dimensional nature of psychopathology. We propose solutions to these challenges by introducing a developmental scaling framework for psychopathology. Using externalizing psychopathology as an example, we draw on our content analysis of externalizing measures, as well as lessons from the study of other constructs across lengthy developmental periods. Addressing these challenges will allow charting individuals' trajectories of psychopathology across the lifespan and identifying risk and protective factors that influence developmental courses.

Keywords: psychopathology, lifespan development, longitudinal trajectories, heterotypic continuity, externalizing behavior problems

Studying Development of Psychopathology Across the Lifespan

When entrenched, psychopathology is costly and difficult to treat ([Insel, 2008](#); [Wakschlag et al., 2019](#)). Understanding its developmental origins is therefore crucial for preventing later, more severe psychopathology. Developmental science seeks to build a bridge that spans the lifespan—from infancy to older adulthood—and not just transitory periods in people's lives. However, the field has not adequately studied individuals' development of psychopathology across the lifespan, instead taking a piecewise approach to development, which limits our understanding of lifespan development and the origins of psychopathology. In this paper, we describe reasons why this is the case—beyond logistical challenges of time and money. And we propose solutions to these challenges by introducing a developmental scaling framework for psychopathology. Using externalizing psychopathology as an example, we draw on our content analysis of over 270 externalizing measures, as well as lessons from the study of other constructs such as academic and cognitive skills across lengthy developmental periods.

The Goal

The Problem/Obstacle

Reasons for the Problem

Beyond logistical challenges of time and money, there are several key reasons why psychology has failed to study people's development of psychopathology, longitudinally, across the lifespan. First, diagnostic and taxonomic systems do not define psychopathology constructs from a developmental perspective. A developmental perspective is crucial because psychopathology constructs often have earlier origins than their full clinical presentation, and forms of psychopathology frequently show changes in behavioral manifestation across development (heterotypic continuity). Second, current assessments do not adequately capture these changes in behavioral manifestation. Third, traditional scoring systems do not allow charting individuals' change over time in the face of changing behavioral manifestation. Fourth, current assessments are not well-suited for capturing the full range of individual differences, despite the dimensional nature of psychopathology.

Solution: A Developmental Scaling Framework

Other Key Challenges to Address

Conclusion

Addressing these challenges will allow charting individuals' trajectories of psychopathology across the lifespan and identifying risk and protective factors that influence their developmental courses. Doing so is critical for understanding how psychopathology develops, when to intervene, and how to most effectively prevent psychopathology.

References

- Insel, T. R. (2008). Assessing the economic costs of serious mental illness. *American Journal of Psychiatry*, 165(6), 663–665. <https://doi.org/10.1176/appi.ajp.2008.08030366>
- Wakschlag, L. S., Roberts, M. Y., Flynn, R. M., Smith, J. D., Krogh-Jespersen, S., Kaat, A. J., Gray, L., Walkup, J., Marino, B. S., Norton, E. S., & Davis, M. M. (2019). Future directions for early childhood prevention of mental disorders: A road map to mental health, earlier. *Journal of Clinical Child & Adolescent Psychology*, 48(3), 539–554. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15374416.2018.1561296>

Appendix A

This Section Is an Appendix

Appendix B

Another Appendix